

**The Invention of the Person:  
A Genealogy of Stratified Personhood**

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## Abstract

Contemporary political and moral thought treats the Person, the autonomous, rational, rights-bearing individual, as a natural category. We treat it as a stratification: a composite assembled over millennia from at least five historical formations, each built by specific institutions to answer a specific problem. Relational personhood, rooted in kinship, ritual, and animism, settles who may be recognized. Epic singularization in *Gilgamesh* and the *Odyssey* makes a single life narratable. Roman law defines the *persona* as a bearer of rights and liabilities. Paul, Augustine, and Boethius add an interior conscience answerable before God and a metaphysical definition of the person. Locke and Kant consolidate the autonomous rational subject that generates moral law from within. The modern individual appears when these layers are fused and retroactively treated as one thing; Hegel's theory of recognition socializes the figure and Foucault's genealogy historicizes it. Contemporary platform capitalism, algorithmic management, the extension of legal personhood to non-human entities, and neurotechnology thin the practical conditions of agency while leaving formal personhood intact. Three small models make parts of the argument auditable. Dating the nine formations reproduces the narrative order over a literate span of 4,075 years. A geometric-mean index with formal support fixed at 1.00 gives a profiled human a practical index of 0.39 and an infrastructural human 0.93. In a recognition network, concentrating recognition on six of 120 agents leaves profiled agents with 0.36 reciprocated ties against 9.5 for the minority. Personhood, having been assembled, can be disassembled; today the disassembly proceeds by hollowing institutional supports while the legal category stays in place.

## 1. Introduction

Modern political, legal, and moral thought is organized around a single figure, the Person. It governs itself. It deliberates, reflects, and chooses. It bears rights that others must respect. It persists over time as the same self that acted yesterday and will act tomorrow. It has a conscience, a will, and motives that matter independently of outward behavior. And it is, in principle, universal: every human being is supposed to be one.

The figure is embedded so deeply in legal codes, political argument, and everyday speech that it looks like a description of what humans are. The genealogy developed below separates it into parts. What is called the Person is the result of a long series of inventions, produced in different centuries and institutional settings, each answering a different question, and later fused into a composite that is treated as though it had always been one thing.

The components differ sharply. In kinship societies, reaching back into deep prehistory, a person is a node in a web of relations, constituted by kin obligations, ritual participation, and shared substance; to be a person is to be properly embedded. Some millennia later the great epics introduce the singular hero, Gilgamesh or Odysseus, a being with a name, a story, and a fate that can be told. The hero stands out from the collective, whereas the kin-embedded person *is* the collective. Rome then adds a further layer. Roman law creates the *persona* as a formal legal category: someone who can own property, enter contracts, sue, and be sued. The Roman *persona* is a bureaucratic technol-

ogy for organizing liability and owes nothing to heroic narrative or kinship obligation. Christianity introduces another dimension. Paul and Augustine place a conscience inside each person, an inner witness that weighs intentions and desires, so that the person acquires depth, an interior life that matters before God regardless of social position or legal standing. Kant finally compresses all of these into one philosophical architecture: the rational autonomous subject that is at once the condition of experience and the source of moral law.

Each construction arose in a specific place, through specific institutions, in response to a specific problem. The kinship person addressed social coordination in small groups. The epic hero made individual lives narratable and memorable. The Roman *persona* addressed legal attribution in a complex empire. The Christian conscience addressed moral responsibility before a universal God. The Kantian subject addressed the grounding of knowledge and morality after traditional authority had lost its hold.

The word “person” in current use carries all five meanings at once, usually unnoticed. The sections below separate the layers, trace where each came from and what it was for, and then ask what happens to the composite when its institutional supports are withdrawn. The thesis is that the Person was assembled in layers and that what was assembled can be disassembled layer by layer.

The claim that the person is a historical category, and no natural kind, has two main predecessors. Marcel Mauss, in his 1938 lecture on the notion of the person and the self, argued that the *personne* and the *moi* have a history, tracing an arc from the Roman juridical *persona* through the Christian moral person to the metaphysical self of Kant and Fichte (Mauss, 1938). Charles Taylor’s *Sources of the Self* gave the modern end of that arc its fullest philosophical genealogy (Taylor, 1989). The present account builds on both and departs from them in three respects. It resolves the single developmental arc into five distinct formations, each tied to the institution and the problem that produced it. It treats the result as a composite that is retroactively naturalized, which makes the question structural (how the layers hold together) as well as historical. And it carries the genealogy into the present, asking what happens to the assembled figure as its institutional supports thin, a question neither predecessor had occasion to consider.

## 2. Layer One: Relational Personhood

### 2.1 The Dividual

The oldest evidence about human selfhood, drawn from archaeology and ethnography, indicates that the bounded individual is a late development. For most of human history, and in many societies today, personhood has been relational and distributed, achieved through social participation and withheld at birth.

Chris Fowler, synthesizing decades of archaeological and anthropological work, states the position directly: “Persons are constituted through relationships not only with other human beings but with things, places, animals and the spiritual features of the cosmos” (Fowler, 2004). Identity in this model is fluid. People pass through stages of personhood during life and after death. The boundary between human and non-human is porous: animals, objects, ancestors, and spirits may

count as persons in some societies, while living humans may fall short of full personhood until they have been ritually integrated.

Melanesian ethnography supplies the most developed theoretical framework for this kind of selfhood. Marilyn Strathern's concept of the "dividual" describes persons composed of the relations in which they participate (Strathern, 1988). On this account a Melanesian person is a composite of substances, names, obligations, and gifts that circulate through social networks, and has no bounded interior holding an inner self. One part of a person belongs to the mother's clan, another to an exchange partner, another was deposited through ritual. The person is made, literally, of relations.

The practical consequences are direct. In many such societies a newborn is not yet a full person. Personhood is achieved through naming ceremonies, through the accumulation of social debts and credits, and through recognition by elders and integration into the kinship system. Someone who dies without proper burial rites may lose personhood and become a dangerous ghost instead of a respected ancestor. Personhood is a status that the community confers and, under certain conditions, withdraws. Victor Turner's analysis of ritual specifies the mechanism: rites of passage carry initiates across a threshold of status, and the rite confers the new standing, which biological maturation alone never supplies (Turner, 1969).

The anthropological literature treats this as a coherent answer to the same question the modern West answers differently. The modern West locates personhood inside the individual, as an inherent property of the biological organism; relational societies locate it in the space between people. Both answers function. They produce different forms of social organization, different moral reasoning, and different vulnerabilities. The relational person is exposed to social exclusion; the bounded individual is exposed to isolation and anomie.

## 2.2 Proto-Personhood in Deep Time

Direct evidence from early hominins is scarce. Deliberate burials and grave goods, attested among Neanderthals and early *Homo sapiens*, point to symbolic thought and to some notion of an afterlife or persistent identity. Evidence that *Homo naledi* practiced intentional interment has pushed these questions further back and reopened debate about the cognitive and moral status of extinct human relatives.

The archaeological record cannot establish whether any of these hominins held a concept of self resembling the modern one. The most defensible reading attributes to them a rudimentary self-awareness embedded in small social groups, a sense of being-with-others that had not yet hardened into the sharp boundary between self and world constructed by later formations. At this depth the self may have resembled a social position more than an inner substance.

## 2.3 Contribution of the Relational Layer

Relational personhood forms the oldest stratum: the self embedded in kinship, ritual, exchange, and cosmic order. It does not produce the modern individual, but it poses the question every later

layer answers in its own way: what makes someone count as a person, and who has the authority to decide?

That question has never been settled for good. Each later layer is a new answer produced under new institutional pressures. The relational layer persists beneath all of them, never fully replaced, and reappears in group identity, social recognition, the desire to belong, and the pain of exclusion.

### 3. Layer Two: Epic Singularization

#### 3.1 Enkidu and Social Integration

The earliest surviving literary epics dramatize becoming a person as a movement from nature into culture, from wildness into social life.

In the *Epic of Gilgamesh*, composed in various forms from roughly 2100 BCE onward, Enkidu embodies this transition. He begins as a wild creature living among animals, drinking at their watering holes, ignorant of human society. He enters the human world through a fixed sequence: sexual initiation with Shamhat, the temple prostitute; the wearing of clothes; bread and beer; entry into the city of Uruk; and, above all, friendship with Gilgamesh. Only after all of these does Enkidu count as human.

In *Gilgamesh*, personhood is social integration. Each step draws Enkidu further from the animal world and deeper into human obligations, pleasures, and limits. He gains language, companionship, grief, and eventually death. The poem presents none of this as automatic: Enkidu's personhood is achieved step by step through encounters with other people and with the institutions of the city. Tzvi Abusch reads Gilgamesh himself as "assembled from multiple identities," part man, part hero, part king, part god, with the poem staging a long conflict between heroic excess and the limits that mortality and communal life impose on even the most powerful individual (Abusch, 2015).

#### 3.2 Odysseus and Recognition Tokens

The *Odyssey*, composed in the 8th century BCE, poses a different problem. *Gilgamesh* concerns becoming a person; the *Odyssey* concerns remaining one. Odysseus spends twenty years away from home, much of it in disguise or among people who do not know him. The poem's central question is whether he can return and be recognized as himself.

The recognition scenes are the poem's main apparatus of personhood. The old nurse Euryycleia sees the scar on his leg and knows him. His dog Argos recognizes him after twenty years and dies. Penelope tests him with a shared secret about their marriage bed. In each case identity is established through a token: a physical mark, a piece of knowledge, a shared history. The scar generalizes: a person is recognized by the marks that a life has left on them.

Identity in the *Odyssey* is relational, since another person must confirm it, and also singular, since it attaches to one individual with one history. Odysseus is interchangeable with no one. His scar, his

bed, his dog, and his marriage are *his*. The poem holds that personhood is a matter of particular biography, that there is something it is to be *this* person and no other.

Bruno Snell's older thesis that Homeric people lacked a unified self has been largely abandoned by classicists. Joseph Russo called Snell's contention "fundamentally misguided," while acknowledging that Homeric psychology differs from later Greek thought (Russo, 2012). The *Odyssey* remains important here for the literary apparatus it develops: the fake autobiography, the strategic concealment of identity, the recognition token, and the question of how one person remains the same across altered circumstances and very different social settings.

### 3.3 Contribution of the Epic Layer

Epic singularization contributes the named, narratable individual: a being with a story, a fate, and a trajectory through time that can be told and retold. The epic person is recognizable, memorable, and distinct from others in ways the relational person of kinship societies need not be. The layer establishes that personhood involves a singular life course, one that can be tested, lost, and recovered.

The epic hero has neither legal standing in the Roman sense nor inner conscience in the Augustinian sense. The hero has a name, a story, and the possibility of being recognized by those who knew him. The contribution has proved durable. Much of what ordinary speech means by "identity", the sense of being a specific someone with a specific past, derives from the epic layer more than from Kant or Roman law.

## 4. Layer Three: Juridical Personhood

### 4.1 The Roman *Persona*

The Romans built something neither kinship societies nor epic poets had attempted: a formal institutional technology for assigning personhood as a legal status. In Roman law *persona* denotes a being that can bear rights and obligations within a legal system. Capacity defines it; inner life and narrative identity are irrelevant to it.

The jurist Gaius, writing in the 2nd century CE, organized the whole of the law around a threefold division: "The whole of the law which we use relates either to persons or to things or to actions." His *Institutes*, a foundational text of European legal education, classify all humans under the "law of persons," organized primarily by the distinction between free and slave: "the primary distinction in the law of persons is that all men are either free or slaves."

The conceptual step is large. For Gaius, personhood is a *legal category*, a status within an institutional system, and whether someone counts as a person depends on whether the law recognizes them as one. A slave is biologically human and can think, feel, suffer, and reason, yet for most legal purposes is a *res*, a thing, an item of property. A free Roman citizen holds full *status capitis*. A foreigner has partial standing. A woman has standing constrained in specific ways. The *paterfa-*

*milius*, the male head of household, holds power over his children and slaves that is itself a form of legal personhood, a node of authority within the legal order.

Rome thus contributes the idea that personhood is an institutional fact. It answers the question of who, within a given legal order, bears rights and obligations, and the answer can include or exclude whomever the legal system chooses. The category of “person” can be broader than “human” (Roman law recognized certain collective entities) and narrower (slaves were human and not fully persons). This flexibility is both the strength and the hazard of juridical personhood: it makes formal legal equality possible, and it makes formal legal exclusion possible. The same technology that eventually produced the Declaration of the Rights of Man also produced the legal infrastructure of slavery.

## 4.2 Contribution of the Juridical Layer

Juridical personhood contributes the formal infrastructure of imputability: the capacity to own, bind, sue, be sued, inherit, and be held answerable. It makes personhood depend on institutional criteria set by a political authority. And it introduces a permanently destabilizing feature: the category of “person” can be detached from the category of “human being” and assigned, expanded, or contracted by whoever controls the legal system.

Contemporary debates about corporate personhood, animal rights, and the legal status of AI operate on this layer. All of them are arguments about where to draw the boundary of the Roman *persona*, conducted in institutions that descend directly from the Roman legal tradition.

## 5. Layer Four: Interior Moral Personhood

### 5.1 Paul and the Inner Witness

The Christian transformation of personhood is the most consequential single development in the genealogy. It added a new dimension: depth.

Before Paul, morality in the Greco-Roman world was largely a matter of action, character, and social reputation. Aristotle’s ethics concerns habituation, virtue, and the good life lived in community. Guilt in the Greek tragic tradition attaches to what was done, even inadvertently: Oedipus is guilty because he killed his father and married his mother, regardless of his intentions or knowledge.

Paul of Tarsus described a law written on the heart, a conscience that serves as an inner witness. The Epistle to the Romans places moral judgment inside each person: even Gentiles, who lack the Mosaic law, “show that the requirements of the law are written on their hearts, their consciences also bearing witness.” With this move, morality ceases to be primarily a matter of public conduct and becomes a matter of what happens within. Intentions, desires, and inner consent acquire a moral weight they had not carried before.

## 5.2 Augustine and the Divided Will

Augustine of Hippo, writing in the 5th century, turned Paul's inwardness into a developed moral psychology. The *Confessions* are, among other things, a sustained investigation of the inner life: the structure of memory, the experience of time, the phenomenon of conflicting desires. Augustine discovered, or constructed, the divided will, the experience of simultaneously wanting and not wanting, of being pulled two ways by desires that reason alone cannot reconcile.

The divided will matters for personhood because it locates moral responsibility below the level of action and even of deliberation. For Augustine sin lies ultimately in the orientation of the will, in what the self loves and consents to. A person can do the right thing for the wrong reason and still be guilty before God; conversely, a person who fails to act rightly out of weakness while genuinely willing the good has also done something of moral significance. The interior theater of guilt, confession, desire, and self-scrutiny that Augustine built shaped Western subjectivity for the next fifteen centuries. The Catholic confessional, Protestant self-examination, psychoanalysis, and modern therapeutic culture all descend, in different ways, from it.

Augustine adds depth to personhood. Before him a person might be a kin-embedded node, a narratable hero, a legal status-holder, or a rational substance. After him a person is also an interior space in which moral dramas unfold unseen, in which the decisive contest between good and evil takes place, and in which the truth about the self is located. This interior makes confession possible and also makes it necessary.

## 5.3 Boethius and the Metaphysical Definition

Boethius, writing in the early 6th century, gave the definition of "person" that medieval philosophy inherited: *naturae rationalis individua substantia*, "an individual substance of a rational nature." The formula makes three claims. A person is metaphysically individual, this particular being, set apart from any class to which it belongs. A person is a substance, existing in its own right and standing under its properties instead of inhering in something else. And a person is rational, capable of thought, judgment, and deliberation.

Boethius formulated the definition within Christological debates about the persons of the Trinity, but its influence reached far beyond theology. Thomas Aquinas adopted it and placed the Boethian person within his hylomorphic metaphysics as a soul-body composite: rational, embodied, and answerable to God. The effect was to give "person" a metaphysical weight it had lacked in Roman law. A Roman *persona* is a legal role; a Boethian person is a *kind of being*. The category moved from the courtroom into the structure of reality.

## 5.4 Contribution of the Interior Layer

Interior moral personhood adds what no earlier layer supplied: an inner life that matters. The relational person is constituted from outside, through social ties. The epic hero is recognized from outside, through tokens and stories. The legal person exists within external institutional structures.

The Augustinian person has an inside, a private theater where desires conflict, conscience speaks, and moral truth is located independently of what anyone else can see or judge.

The same layer that makes confession possible also makes surveillance attractive. If the truth about a person lies hidden inside them, institutions that want that truth (the Church, the state, the therapeutic professions, the data platform) will develop increasingly sophisticated techniques for reaching the interior. The history of confession, interrogation, psychological testing, and behavioral analytics can be read as a history of attempts to reach the space Augustine opened.

## 6. Layer Five: The Autonomous Rational Subject

### 6.1 Descartes and the Thinking Substance

Descartes precedes Locke and Kant in the construction. His *cogito ergo sum* places the thinking self at the foundation of all knowledge: the one thing that cannot be doubted is that one is thinking (Descartes, 1641). The self becomes a thinking substance, a *res cogitans*, distinct in kind from the extended material world. Descartes does not use the word “person” in his most influential arguments, but he establishes the modern equation of selfhood with consciousness on which Locke builds.

### 6.2 Locke: Person as a Forensic Term

John Locke, writing at the end of the 17th century, reframed the person in psychological and legal terms at once. A person, Locke writes, is “a thinking, intelligent Being, that has reason and reflection, and can consider itself as itself, the same thinking thing in different times and places” (Locke, 1689). The definition is psychological. Locke then adds that “person” is a *forensic term*: “appropriating actions and their merit; and so belongs only to intelligent agents, capable of a law, and happiness, and misery.”

A forensic concept exists for the purpose of attribution. The category of person is needed to say that this individual did this thing, is responsible for it, and can be rewarded or punished accordingly. For Locke, personal identity across time is continuity of consciousness, specifically of memory. Someone is the same person who committed a crime last year because they can remember committing it, or at least remember being the kind of being who could have committed it. Where memory is absent and consciousness fully discontinuous, Locke treats sameness of person as a genuine open question.

The conception is practical. It detaches personhood from the soul (Locke argues explicitly that personal identity does not depend on substance, material or immaterial) and attaches it to the continuity of self-awareness over time. A person is whatever can reflectively appropriate its own past actions and be held accountable for them.

### 6.3 Hume's Challenge

David Hume, a generation after Locke, dismantled the project. Looking inward for the self, Hume reported finding nothing: "I never can catch myself at any time without a perception, and never can observe anything but the perception" (Hume, 1739). The self, in his phrase, is a "bundle of perceptions," a stream of experiences with no underlying substance holding it together. If Hume is right, the unified, continuous person Locke describes is a fiction, a habit of the mind with no real entity behind it.

The result was a crisis. The legal and moral systems of modern Europe required a stable, continuous person who could be held responsible across time, and Hume's empiricism threatened to dissolve that person into a sequence of impressions. Kant's intervention answers this crisis.

### 6.4 Kant: Transcendental Unity and Autonomy

Kant, writing in the late 18th century, resolved the crisis by changing the question. He conceded that the self cannot be found as an object of experience; on that point Hume was right. He argued instead that the self is presupposed as a *condition* of experience. The "I think" must be able to accompany all my representations; without a unified subject there would be no experience at all, only unconnected sensory fragments (Kant, 1781). The self is therefore a transcendental requirement, and no empirical discovery could supply or remove it.

On the moral side Kant produced an equally strong synthesis. Every rational being, he argued, must be regarded as an end in itself and never merely as a means to someone else's purposes (Kant, 1785). The source of this dignity is rational autonomy, the capacity to give oneself moral law. The person is an autonomous lawgiver: moral law comes from the rational will legislating universally, and neither God, the state, nor tradition is its source.

Kant achieved the most comprehensive assembly of personhood in the Western tradition. The Boethian "individual substance of a rational nature" survives: the person is metaphysically real. The Lockean forensic person survives: the person is accountable across time. The Augustinian interior survives: the person has a moral will that matters. To these Kant adds universality and autonomy: every rational being has equal dignity, and moral law is generated from within.

Modernity inherits this figure. The claim that every human being has inherent dignity and inalienable rights is stated in Kantian language, whether or not its speakers know it. The five layers of personhood have been compressed into one architecture and declared to be the essence of being human.

### 6.5 Contribution of the Rational Layer

The autonomous rational subject contributes universality and self-legislation. Every rational being has equal dignity, and moral authority is internal, generated by the rational will instead of imposed by external power. The layer is the capstone of the stratification, the point at which all earlier layers

are declared aspects of a single figure. It is also the most vulnerable layer, because it depends on all the others while claiming to need none of them.

## 7. Socialization and Historicization

### 7.1 Hegel and Mutual Recognition

Soon after Kant, Hegel argued that the autonomous subject cannot stand alone. Self-consciousness, on his account, does not arise in isolation; it requires mutual recognition, and one's freedom becomes actual only when another free being acknowledges it (Hegel, 1807). The master-slave dialectic in the *Phenomenology of Spirit* makes the point sharply. The master dominates the slave and thereby destroys the possibility of genuine recognition, because coerced acknowledgment has no value. Genuine recognition requires equality, and equality requires institutions.

In the *Philosophy of Right* Hegel described those institutions. Three spheres, family, civil society, and the state, together constitute *Sittlichkeit*, ethical life (Hegel, 1820). The family provides love and intimate recognition; civil society provides economic interaction and the recognition of needs and labor; the state provides legal and political recognition as a citizen. Personhood is fully realized only within this institutional framework. The solitary Kantian subject, legislating moral law in the privacy of its own reason, is an abstraction; actual personhood is social, institutional, and historical.

Hegel's contribution is to show that the Kantian person depends on specific social conditions for its existence. Where the institutions of mutual recognition are removed, personhood thins even though the biological organism remains intact.

### 7.2 Foucault and the Production of the Subject

Michel Foucault, writing in the second half of the 20th century, extended the genealogy one step further. For Foucault the modern subject is produced by power. The autonomous individual of Enlightenment thought is, he argued, the outcome of specific historical arrangements: disciplinary institutions (prisons, schools, hospitals, barracks), administrative techniques (record-keeping, examination, classification), and biopolitical regimes that manage populations in addition to ruling territories (Foucault, 1975).

Foucault distinguished older forms of power, in which the sovereign's authority was exercised through spectacular punishment and the right to kill, from modern biopower, which "endeavors to administer, optimize, and multiply life, subjecting it to precise controls and comprehensive regulations" (Foucault, 1976). Under biopower the state manages as well as forbidding and commanding. It produces norms, measures deviations, administers populations, and creates the categories through which individuals understand themselves.

The genealogical claim is that the Person was manufactured by institutions and then attributed to nature. The rational, autonomous, self-knowing individual Kant describes is a historical product of the disciplinary and administrative practices that emerged in early modern Europe. The Person is a

construction in the strong sense: it required specific institutional conditions to come into existence and requires their continuation to survive.

Foucault's later work complicated the picture. In his final lectures and writings on the "care of the self," he acknowledged that subjects take part in practices of self-formation, *techniques du soi*, through which they shape themselves within, and sometimes against, the systems that constitute them (Foucault, 1984). Personhood, for the later Foucault, is a site of struggle.

### 7.3 Summary of the Sequence

The genealogy can be summarized as a sequence of layers, each added to those before it:

**relational embedding** (kinship, ritual) → **narrative singularity** (epic) → **legal status** (Rome) → **inner conscience** (Paul, Augustine) → **metaphysical substance** (Boethius, Aquinas) → **self-conscious continuity** (Locke) → **transcendental autonomy** (Kant) → **social recognition** (Hegel) → **historical production** (Foucault)

Each step adds a layer without fully replacing the earlier ones, and the modern Person holds all of them at once. The accumulation accounts for the concept's richness and also for its fragility: when the institutional support for any single layer is withdrawn, the composite begins to thin.

## 8. The Contemporary Thinning

### 8.1 Formal Personhood and Practical Agency

Under contemporary conditions personhood is thinning while the formal category persists. Legal personhood has in fact expanded and now covers more entities than ever. The practical conditions that give personhood its substance, namely bargaining power, privacy, the ability to contest decisions, access to meaningful political participation, and control over one's own attention and information environment, are being eroded for large parts of the population and concentrated in a small one.

The problem differs in shape from the exclusions that earlier critics identified. In the 19th century many categories of people, including women, colonized peoples, and the propertyless, were shut out of formal personhood. The 21st-century problem lies one layer deeper. Almost everyone is formally included and holds, on paper, the rights and dignities of a person. The thinning occurs in the practical capacity to exercise those rights, to make choices that are one's own, and to contest the systems that classify and manage one's life.

A worker whose schedule is set by an algorithm they cannot see or appeal has formal personhood. So does a citizen whose political influence is negligible beside that of a billionaire, and a user whose attention is shaped by recommendation engines optimized for engagement. In each case the Kantian shell of equal dignity, inherent rights, and rational autonomy is intact. What has been withdrawn is the practical infrastructure that gives these things effect.

## 8.2 Two Grades of Personhood

The result is a society with two functional grades of personhood, here called *profiled* and *infrastructural*.

The profiled human is measured, predicted, segmented, and steered. Their choices remain formally free: no one forces them to click, buy, vote, or behave in any particular way. The environment in which they choose, however, has been engineered by people and systems they do not control and often cannot identify, so as to produce predictable outcomes. Algorithmic management in workplaces evaluates, schedules, and disciplines through systems whose logic is opaque. Content recommendation selects the information environment. Credit scoring determines access to housing and finance. Each system acts on the profiled human from outside, shaping the conditions of choice while leaving choice formally in place.

The infrastructural human builds, owns, or controls these systems: the platforms, the compute, the data pipelines, the networks, the legal teams, and the political access. The same systems that constrain everyone else amplify their agency. They design decision architectures in addition to living within them.

The asymmetry separates two kinds of person, and a single scale does not capture it. Both the profiled and the infrastructural human are legal persons, both hold rights, and both can in principle go to court, yet the practical substance of their personhood differs radically. One is the subject of the systems and the other is their author.

The genealogy explains why the situation is hard to name. Because all five layers are formally preserved, the legal category is intact, and autonomy and dignity are still proclaimed, the thinning is invisible to the inherited vocabulary. The language of rights, autonomy, and dignity was built for a world in which the main threat to personhood was exclusion from the category. It is poorly equipped for a world in which the main threat is the emptying of the category from within.

## 8.3 The Epistemic Dimension

The thinning has an epistemic dimension. Each historical layer of personhood was produced through specific mediating channels. Ritual, epic, law, theology, and philosophy are, among other things, information channels: they transmit a picture of what a person is, and in transmitting it they help bring into existence the kind of person they describe.

The five layers can accordingly be read as five successive regimes of mediation, each of which shaped the believing agent as well as the agent's beliefs about the world. Ritual produces kin-embedded persons, epic produces narratable heroes, law produces legal subjects, theology produces guilty consciences, and philosophy produces autonomous reasoners. In each case the channel constitutes as well as informs.

Contemporary platform capitalism introduces a new regime. The algorithmic feed, the recommendation engine, and the behavioral nudge determine what the agent sees and, at a more basic level,

whether the agent deliberates at all or is optimized (Pariser, 2011). The channel's effect shifts from distorting the world as it reaches the agent to reshaping the agent.

#### **8.4 The Expansion of Legal Personhood**

Meanwhile the legal category of "person" has expanded in ways that reveal the concept's nature. Corporations have held legal personhood for centuries. In recent decades rivers and forests have been granted legal personality in some jurisdictions, including New Zealand and Ecuador. AI systems, as they acquire capacities for planning, learning, and generating language, are beginning to raise the question of whether some form of legal recognition is appropriate or inevitable.

The expansion supports the genealogy's central claim. Legal personhood was never a natural kind; it was always an institutional assignment, a decision by a political authority about who or what would count as a bearer of rights and obligations. Extension to non-human entities makes this uncomfortably visible, because it shows that a category believed to track something essential about human nature tracks a political choice about institutional inclusion.

The expansion also thins the concept. The more heterogeneous the set of entities that count as persons, the less the category says about any one of them. Where a human being, a corporation, a river, and an AI system are all "persons," the word has become very general, possibly too general to do the moral and political work the Kantian synthesis assigned to it.

#### **8.5 Neurotechnology and the Fragmented Self**

Neuroscience adds a further source of destabilization. Research over several decades has shown that the brain's sense of unified selfhood can be disrupted, fragmented, or altered by injury, drugs, electrical stimulation, and disease. Split-brain patients show behavior suggesting two centers of experience within one skull. Dissociative identity disorder shows that one brain can generate multiple distinct personality states. Psychedelic research has shown that the sense of self can be temporarily dissolved and reconstituted.

If consciousness is a pattern instantiated in a physical substrate, that pattern can in principle be split, copied, or migrated, and the question of personhood separates from the question of biological humanity. An uploaded mind, if one became possible, would satisfy the Lockean criterion of continuity of consciousness. A sufficiently sophisticated AI system might satisfy the Boethian criterion of rational individuality. A brain organoid grown in a laboratory satisfies none of the epic, juridical, or theological criteria, yet it raises questions of moral status that the existing framework struggles to answer.

The five-layer genealogy explains why these prospects are destabilizing. Existing institutions assume that all five layers co-occur in one entity: one body, one name, one legal status, one conscience, one rational will. Neurotechnology threatens to decouple them. One body might house several persons; one person might be instantiated in several bodies. Personhood might become modular, composed of detachable components that can be distributed across substrates and recombined.

## 9. Computational Models

The genealogy makes structural claims: layers assembled in an order, held together by supports, and thinning when supports are withdrawn while the formal category persists. Three small models in the accompanying simulation/ make parts of that structure auditable. None of them measures history. Each restates one claim from the preceding sections in a form that can be recomputed and disputed. Numbers are written to simulation/output/results.json and figures to simulation/output/figures/.

### 9.1 Dated Stratigraphy

The first model dates the nine formations by the works that first attest them and sorts them by emergence. Sorting by date reproduces the narrative order of sections 2 through 7 without rearrangement: relational personhood in deep prehistory, epic singularization with *Gilgamesh* around 2100 BCE, juridical personhood in the Roman legal tradition, interior conscience with Paul, metaphysical substance with Boethius, self-conscious continuity with Locke, transcendental autonomy with Kant, social recognition with Hegel, and historical production with Foucault. The order presented on conceptual grounds is also the chronological order, which is the minimum the stratigraphic claim requires.

The dates quantify “assembled over millennia.” From the epic layer to Foucault the span is 4,075 years; including the relational layer in deep prehistory extends it past a hundred thousand. The intervals are uneven. The longest literate gap, 1,650 years, separates epic singularization from Roman juridical personhood. The second longest, 1,169 years, is the medieval interval between Boethius and Locke, during which the metaphysical definition stood without the self-continuity layer Locke later added. The composite did not accrete at a steady rate. Long periods separate additions, consistent with each layer requiring a specific institutional occasion. The dates are representative onsets chosen from the cited works, and the gaps inherit their imprecision.

### 9.2 Composite Personhood Index

The second model formalizes the central claim of section 8: personhood can be formally intact and practically drained at once, and the draining is unequal. Each of five layers rests on two supports, one formal and one practical, each scored between zero and one. The personhood index is the geometric mean of the layer supports. A geometric mean matches the argument of section 7.3, since a single near-zero layer pulls the index down however strong the others are, whereas a sum would let strong layers compensate.

With formal support held at its maximum for every layer, the formal index is 1.00, corresponding to the legal category that section 8.4 describes as intact and expanding. The scenarios diverge on the practical index. A profiled human, with belonging, narratable identity, capacity to contest, inner privacy, and self-directed attention all partly drained, scores 0.39 on the practical index while remaining at 1.00 formally; the gap of 0.61 expresses “formally a person, practically thinned” as a quantity. An infrastructural human, whose agency the same systems amplify, scores 0.93. The

practical personhood of the two grades differs by a factor of about 2.4 at identical formal personhood. The support values are stipulated, so the model inherits the asymmetry from the claims of section 8 and does not discover it. It checks that the claims compose: “formally intact, practically unequal” is a coherent joint state of the index.

### 9.3 Recognition Network

The third model takes Hegel’s claim from section 7.1 that personhood is realized only through mutual recognition and asks how realized recognition changes when the field becomes asymmetric. A population of 120 agents recognize one another, and realized personhood is measured as reciprocated recognition, the relations that run in both directions. In an egalitarian field, where recognition is mutual by construction, each agent reciprocates with about fourteen others on average and the inequality of recognition received is low.

The concentrated field models the asymmetry of section 8.2. A small infrastructural minority, six agents in a hundred and twenty, receives recognition from everyone but reciprocates mainly within itself. Reciprocated recognition then collapses for the majority: a profiled agent retains on average about 0.36 mutual ties, while an infrastructural agent retains about 9.5, a ratio of more than twenty-five to one. The Gini coefficient of recognition received rises from 0.13 in the egalitarian field to 0.61 in the concentrated one. Every agent is still recognized in the thin sense of being seen and counted by the system. What most agents lose is reciprocity, which on the Hegelian account is what makes recognition constitutive of a self and distinguishes it from registration. On this reading the thinning of section 8 leaves persons inside the category and concentrates in a few hands the mutual relation through which the category was supposed to become actual.

### 9.4 Limitations

The three models are illustrative. The emergence dates are representative onsets, and the relational date in particular is a placeholder for deep prehistory. The layer supports in the index are stipulated scores, so the index shows internal consistency and has no empirical calibration. The recognition network is a single random draw with fixed connection probabilities; its ratios describe that draw and would shift with other seeds or densities, although the qualitative collapse of reciprocity follows from the construction.

## 10. Conclusion

The modern Person is a composite. Its oldest strata are communal and role-based: the self embedded in kinship, ritual, and cosmic order. Epic individuality, legal standing, inner conscience, metaphysical substance, and rational autonomy were added over time. The contemporary Person appears only when all of these layers coincide, when a single being has a name, a story, a legal status, an answerable conscience, and a self-legislating will.

This coincidence was produced historically, by specific institutions for specific purposes over several thousand years. The Person was stratified layer by layer, and it can be de-stratified layer by layer if the institutional conditions supporting each layer are withdrawn or transformed.

The contemporary thinning of personhood follows these lines. Formal legal personhood is intact and expanding. The practical substance of agency, the capacity to deliberate, to contest, and to shape the conditions of one's own life, is being drained for large populations and concentrated in a small one. The channels through which persons formed themselves (ritual, narrative, law, theology, philosophy) are being supplemented, and in some cases replaced, by algorithmic systems that optimize behavior without forming agents. Everyone remains a person on paper while fewer people are persons in practice.

Defending personhood therefore requires knowing what it is made of. It is made of institutional supports: kinship structures that embed, narratives that singularize, legal systems that recognize, moral traditions that deepen, philosophical frameworks that universalize, and political institutions that enable mutual recognition. Each can be strengthened or weakened, and each is currently under pressure. The open political question is whether the practical substance of personhood will survive systems that manage persons without abolishing them.

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